

Postwar analysis

In the postwar period, Allied strategic bombing retrospectively came under criticism on practical and moral grounds. Practically, it was said to have wasted resources that could have been better used to other military purposes.

Morally, it was attacked for deliberately or inadvertently causing the deaths of hundreds of thousands of civilians.

Certainly, it had taken a long time to achieve air superiority and to field the numbers of bombers and develop the bombs needed to devastate the enemy's heartland. Yet in the end it had, and few Germans or Japanese would be inclined to minimize the bombing's impact. As for morality, in wartime it soon comes to seem natural to harm your enemy as much as you can and in any way that you can, and this truth governed the use of bombers from Warsaw and Rotterdam to Hiroshima and Nagasaki.

Morality of war

The bomber commanders were hard men.

A story is told of Arthur Harris that once during the war he was stopped by a British policeman for

speeding in his car: "You'll kill someone if you go on driving like that," said the policeman. "Young man," Harris replied, "I kill hundreds of people every night." When LeMay was asked after the war about the morality of what the bombers had

done, he was typically forthright: "To worry about the morality of what we were doing? Nuts! A soldier has to fight. We fought. If we accomplished the job in any given battle without losing too many of our own folks that was a pretty good day." Airmen have expressed similar views. Melvin Larsen,

who flew in B-17s, stated that bombing never gave him concern because: "I knew that each time we dropped our bombs... helped to bring the ending of the war that much closer." The airmen had a job to do, and they did it, at great risk to their lives.

"Thank God the war is over and I don't have to get shot at any more. I can go home."

THEODORE VAN KIRK
ENOLA GAY NAVIGATOR

DAYLIGHT RAIDERS

B-29 Superfortresses release their powerful bombloads on a high-level daylight mission. The American bombers achieved their maximum effectiveness in conventional raids on Japan when they were switched to low-altitude night raids with incendiaries.

THE BOMBING OF HIROSHIMA

ON AUGUST 6, 1945, AT 2:45AM local time, a B-29 bomber took off from Tinian Island in the Marianas carrying the world's first operational atomic bomb. In command was Colonel Paul W. Tibbets, head of 509th Composite Group, set up the previous year to deliver America's secret weapon. Tibbets had his mother's maiden name, *Enola Gay*, painted on the nose.

With the 4.8-ton *Little Boy* bomb on board, the *Enola Gay* was overweight and gave a few anxious moments on takeoff, but after that the six-hour flight went without notable incident. On the way the *Enola Gay* rendezvoused with two other B-29s that were to accompany it to the target and observe the big event. The crew did their jobs – navigation, preparing the bomb – and snacked on coffee and ham sandwiches. Weather-reconnaissance aircraft radioed that the weather over the first-choice target, the city of Hiroshima, was mostly clear.

LITTLE BOY

The atomic bomb dropped on Hiroshima was 10ft (3m) long and weighed 9,700lb (4,400kg). It exploded with the force of 13,800 tons of TNT.

At 8:40am the *Enola Gay* approached the city at over 30,000ft (9,000m). Copilot Robert Lewis, who was scribbling a commentary on the mission, wrote: "There will be a short intermission while we bomb our target." Bombardier Major Thomas Ferebee took over control of the aircraft through the Norden bombsight and released *Little Boy* to airburst over the Aioi Bridge. The bomber jumped as the weight dropped away, then filled with an unbearably bright light. The first shock wave struck the plane with such force that Tibbets thought they had been hit by flak.

As the mushroom cloud rose and the ground below boiled, Tibbet announced: "Fellows, you have just dropped the first atomic bomb in history." The crew had trained hard for that moment and were relieved that it had worked. Navigator Theodore Van Kirk thought: "Thank God the war is over and I don't have to get shot at any more. I can go home."

ENOLA GAY CREW

The men who dropped the atomic bomb on Hiroshima: the leader of the mission, Colonel Tibbets, is third from the right in the back row, flanked by bombardier Major Ferebee on his right and copilot Captain Lewis on his left.

